

(This is not) An ACL Story

Everything I thought was wrong ¹

The day started on the turf soccer field at Groveport Madison High School. The dog-breath summer heat bore down on 16-year-old Jade and the other “Cruisers” as they ran laps and fought through Coach Mark’s conditioning drills, trying to strengthen themselves for the upcoming season. The team was sweaty and tired when they began to scrimmage, and Jade, with her dark hair whipping around in a ponytail behind her, sprinted up to receive a pass from her teammate... then heard a crunch. She fell to the floor, with an unforgettable sensation shooting from her knee throughout the rest of her body. Her team came to check on her, and she discovered she could not get herself off the field. Seconds before she had been sprinting full speed, and suddenly, she just couldn’t walk anymore. Coach Mark drove her off the field in his cart, before calling her older sister, Linda. She worriedly brought Jade home and deposited her on the couch, where she stayed for the rest of the day.

I was familiar with my close friend Jade’s story of how she tore her ACL, and wanted to know more about how this experience affected her. In preparing to interview her, I began to read about others who had torn their ACL, and was saddened by what I found: “An ACL injury is no longer a career killer, but can athletes ever truly be the same?” The Guardian’s Ian McMahan punctuates this grim title with an equally grim picture of Major League Baseball player Adam Eaton (who had recently torn his ACL) lying curled up on the ground, with his face in the dirt. This image triggers an empathetic cringe in me, as the article’s title sets up the audience to know that this athlete is not only in physical pain, but his career, livelihood, and legacy in the sport is

¹ Villarosa, *Under the Skin*, 1.

at stake.² Similarly, less than a month ago, an article in ESPN titled “Sources: Initial fear is Giants' Daniel Jones has torn ACL” was released, and author Jordan Raanan underscores the titular reference to “fear” with phrases and quotes such as “his fate will ultimately be determined...” “pray for him”, “latest punch to the gut” and “devastating”.³ Even the fictional Demon Copperhead shares in their pain when he suffers a highschool career ending knee injury... “My future was football. Playing through the pain is what you do.”

While dealing with intense physical pain, instability that can stop one from walking without crutches, and surgery flanked by months of physical therapy, athletes must simultaneously ponder if they are doomed to be a disappointment to themselves and others when they return, if they can return at all.^{4 5}

Reading these stories, I feared my close friend’s story would be painted with the same jarring pictures. Physical and emotional agony, dread for the future, pleads to a higher power to be able to return... As I read her physical therapist Katie’s notes evaluating her listed goals for recovery, my fear cemented itself; “Patient still not able to perform the following activities at pre injury/condition level: walk, negotiate stairs, squat, perform ADLs, participate in sport.”⁶ My heart sank, knowing she still has not set foot on a soccer field or volleyball court (her other sport at the time) 2 and a half years later. I walked into the interview apprehensively, bracing myself for the sad narrative I was sure to hear:

“I personally think... having an ACL tear was ... weirdly kind of a good thing.”

² McMahan, “An ACL Injury Is No Longer a Career Killer, but Can Athletes Ever Truly Be the Same?”

³ Raanan, “Sources: Giants Fear.”

⁴ “Anterior Cruciate Ligament (ACL) Injury: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia.”

⁵ “ACL Reconstruction.”

⁶ “7-26-21 Appointment Note.”

Fear of Failure

As you get to know Jade, you'll notice she brings ambition and grit to everything she does. She graduated valedictorian from her high school class, with a rainbow of cords decorating her neck, celebrating her many honors and awards. She also played volleyball and later soccer, and her commitment to volleyball wasn't any different from her commitment to her academics: "I worked out like three times a day just for volleyball." Color me impressed, I'm writing this while eating takis flamin' hot cheetos on the couch. I called it crazy, and she agreed: "It's crazy [and yet,] I really loved it," she said. The joy in her voice was indisputable.

Her first workout was cardio, to build the base endurance for long matches. The second was meant to increase her vertical jump; an essential for any play including blocking, attacking, serving, and defensive plays.⁷ The third one was geared towards technique, mechanics, precision, and form on the court are an indisputable need. What drove her to practice so much, I wondered? Her answer: a fear of failure.

"In volleyball... you make a lot of mistakes. And then you know fear a failure comes up and you're like of course I don't wanna fail so I'm gonna practice. So every time you do mess up, it feels like another weight on your shoulders."

So, practice she did. Somehow, she fit in a fourth daily workout for scheduled practice with the Groveport Madison team, and people started to take notice of her success. First, it was her coach: She had only just started playing in 8th grade, but by sophomore year, she was the team's full time Libero. As the best passer and the fastest player, she was their defensive backbone. She was essential for serves, receiving, and sets, so she was the one player who never

⁷ Popelka, "The Vertical Jump."

got subbed in or left the court during games. It was impressive, but it also meant she was expected to be performing at her best for the full day.

The team captains would be the second to take notice, but not in a good way. In her opinion, the entire team had “a stick up their ass,” but the captains were by far the worst culprits. They were popular, but moody and miserable, and would frequently sink the team’s already low morale by placing blame, instead of encouraging teammates. They were “not nice to anyone,” but had an axe to grind with Jade specifically: “if you got moved up they did not treat you normally. They made it very obvious they didn't want you there.”

While she did not get along with the captains or many others on the team because of this, there were exceptions. First, there was Millie, who Jade had known since childhood, and who was always there for her. There was also Angeline, with her silky dark hair and bright eyed smile. They were like “three triplets” in their team.

However, there was something different about Angeline. Jade remembers going to volleyball and consistently thinking, “if I do bad in front of her, this is gonna be the most embarrassing moment of my life.” In a way, the coach and her teammates weren’t the only ones who she felt watching her. At the time, Jade was realizing that she was “weirdly interested” in the lives of some of the girls she knew, including Angeline. It had happened before, but multiple times? “Why is that a pattern?” she wondered. Combined with the general disinterest she had in boys, the pieces were starting to click into place. “OH! *That’s* a thing.” But with the realization came the shame: the fear of telling anyone, of what her parents would think, would they hate her if she told them? “It was a source of proper anxiety...I [felt] like I had to hide... I couldn't explain it [to my parents] and then I think they could tell something was different.” What “that” is, would have to remain unnamed.

Things Imagined

But Angeline wasn't paying that much attention to her success, let alone judging her or seeing Jade as a failure. It was easy to point to Angeline's gaze as the reason behind why she felt she was failing, but in reality it was really just her "own mindset" making her feel that way. Her repression of her sexuality would further impact her evaluation of herself:

"When you're young especially, there's like a lot of worry that you'll like never be loved, right?... And especially because I was like never in a relationship before, it was just like very much like a, [it's] never happening. I'm always gonna feel one sided love, ... from that moment it's like, oh my god, I'm just crazy. No one could ever love me, like, super dramatic stuff... it makes sense because you're a kid. You go through all this stuff and then you feel real like sadness. And its like, it feels like nothing's getting better..."

Bria Godley's quote from "Things Imagined" sums it up: "Things that are perceived as real are real in their consequences."⁸ Of course, Jade is not unloveable, and she truly was not failing in front of Angeline or anyone else. But she perceived these things to be true, which took a deep toll on her: She referred to this period in her life as the "9 months depression" and confided in me that she had self harmed and had made a plan to take her own life, that she frequently considered following through on. Though Jade admits that there were other factors fueling her mental health issues besides her struggles within volleyball and with her sexuality, her mental state and fear of failure was epitomized by these experiences. Indeed, she states that "if you think about it logically, what do you really have to lose by asking someone out?...[I]t's just the fear. And then that fear coincided everywhere else [in my life]."

⁸ Godley, "Things Imagined."

But again, nobody else saw her as failing. At the end of her sophomore year, with her self esteem in the gutter, Jade's coach put her up for varsity. To anyone else this would have been an opportunity and an accomplishment, but to Jade: it was "another way to fail."

Angeline and Millie had quit long ago, so her ties to volleyball were growing weaker. With the coaches varsity offer at the end of sophomore year, Jade decided it was time for her to leave as well.

Stagnation

But our ambitious student athlete wasn't quite ready to be done with team sports. When Angeline had left volleyball, she joined the soccer team. Angeline convinced Jade to join her for summer conditioning and to consider officially joining in a few months when junior year started.

But joining soccer wasn't the change Jade needed. She never pursued Angeline, and things with her started to fade, but a new girl on the team came to the forefront of Jade's focus: Lily. She was confident, if not a little "insane" at times. To a shy and reserved Jade, that confidence was everything she wanted to be but wasn't: "It felt like she was like what I was not... I was almost convinced I was like in love with her." She never pursued Lily either. It was a new girl, new sport, but the same story.

One big difference in notable change, although completely unintended, was Jade inadvertently found herself in the highest risk bracket for ACL tears: Highschool girls are more likely to tear their ACL than boys, and soccer is a high risk sport, alongside football and basketball, due to the frequency of contact force- such as a slide tackle to intercept a pass.⁹ We saw how that story ended. No more than a month into joining soccer, she found herself clutching her leg on the turf.

⁹ MacDonald, Rodenberg, and Sweeney, "Acute Knee Injuries in Children and Adolescents."

Missing Pieces

Ten days later, after hopping around on one leg and sliding down the stairs, Jade made her way to a doctor's office. It wasn't a doctor she had ever seen before.¹⁰ She states that she was assigned a different doctor every time she needed healthcare due to her family's insurance situation. This is when the discrepancies between the accounts given between her and her healthcare providers began to emerge.

She wasn't certain she had an ACL tear, but she "had a feeling" what the prognosis would be. Soccer Coach Mark had told her that it was likely an ACL tear, and within a week she would probably be able to know. Though she wasn't exactly certain, what she did know for certain was that "It was never gonna be the same....Something was missing. I knew it. I felt it". One X-ray and MRI later, the self described "something missing" was revealed to be the ligament connecting her thigh bone (femur) and her shin bone (tibia): her official diagnoses was a complete ACL rupture, with bruising on the outside bones and a possible lateral meniscal tear in her left knee.¹¹

The magnitude of Jade's words and her clear consideration of her coach's advice seemed clear to me; however, her physical therapist Katie commented on official documentation that Jade "saw [a] doctor 2 weeks later because [she] wasn't sure if it was serious but [she] couldn't walk. [She] was hopping around for 2 weeks." At worst, her words read as sarcastic and judgmental of Jade's choice to delay seeking medical aid (notably, Katie did misconstrue the timeline slightly, according to the dates on other official medical documentation). At best, it shows the disconnect between patient and provider expectations. Medline recommends one seeing a doctor "right away" if an ACL tear is suspected, so PT Katie's distress at a perceived

¹⁰ "6-3-21 Appointment Note."

¹¹ "6-15-21 Appointment Note."

late visit is somewhat understandable, but in reality Jade was quite intentional about following her coach's advice for seeking out healthcare, and was not dismissing the severity of her condition.¹²

I wondered if Jade would be uncomfortable with Katie's description, but when I read this quote to Jade, she laughed, stated out loud that they must think she was "crazy" for waiting, but ultimately brushed it off as "a different perspective." Whereas medical professionals "can understand it based on [their] terminology" to her, "I'm just a kid. It's very simple." She saw it her way, and they saw it theirs.

Once the diagnosis was determined, it was time for an intervention. "We had a long discussion today with Jade and her mother. With her injury, age and activity level, we would recommend surgical intervention in the form of an ACL reconstruction."¹³

Jade's commentary was a little less official. She recalls that the practitioners told her she had torn her ACL, "and then someone was like, 'hey, you're having surgery' and it was like 'okay. I'm having surgery.'" I asked her if it felt like she got to make a choice in her treatment plan, I was met with a sarcastic jab: "Well, do I want to walk? Normally? That's, I mean, those are the 2 choices really ... You don't have a choice basically."

Finally, the stated goals of her surgery and PT were different from what Jade wanted. Our society recognizes and sympathizes with the role loss of an athlete due to a sports injury at a high level, as illustrated by articles such as McMahan's. So, doctor's use Return to Sport (RTS) as a major criterion for ACL Reconstruction Surgery (ARS). One article states, "The desire to return to movement with equal to or close to pre-injury levels is an extremely important expectation and psychological response of patients with the ACL injury, so the evaluation criteria for ACL

¹² "Anterior Cruciate Ligament (ACL) Injury: MedlinePlus Medical Encyclopedia."

¹³ "6-15-21 Appointment Note."

reconstruction surgery has gradually shifted from injury-based angle such as joint stability to sport participation-based perspective such as RTS rate in recent years”¹⁴

Indeed, her medical records are littered with criteria of “Return to Sport.” Her PT reports are titled “Sports and Orthopedic Physical Therapy” Treatment Notes¹⁵. Katie writes that Jade’s primary goals include “Go to stores, go out for walks, play soccer, walk”¹⁶ and indicates a timeline of returning to soccer by the “spring semester”¹⁷ While walking was a genuine concern and goal of hers, as evidenced by her belief she had “no choice” but to have surgery if she ever wanted to walk again, I asked her if the other goals were real goals, she laughed, and cried “It’s Bullshit!... Katie was like, what do you wanna do? And I was like, ‘fuck I don’t know?’ And she was like, ‘okay, we’re gonna make up stuff.’” She allowed Katie to fill in random goals, including regaining the ability to go to some fictional store to pick up groceries for her parents (a chore she had never been assigned), and returning to a sport she “didn’t really ever care about” and that she didn’t really want to play again. As Jade and Katie got to know each other more over the course of physical therapy sessions, the goals began to be more practical and believable: they included the ability to “walk, negotiate stairs, squat, perform ADLs...” and of course, tacked onto the end, to “participate in sport.”¹⁸ When tasked with making up stuff, a master narrative of what a fictional Jade would want emerged by Katie and Jade’s hand: and it somehow included returning to soccer. Our societal drive to “return to sport” post-injury likely drove the inclusion of a completely fictional goal on an official medical record.

Granted, the division of “Sports Medicine” got its name for a reason. There is nothing wrong with wanting to help adolescents return to their sports, when so many of them desperately

¹⁴ Du et al., “Current Study on the Influence of Psychological Factors on Returning to Sports after ACLR.”

¹⁵ “6-22-21 Appointment Note.”

¹⁶ “6-22-21 Appointment Note.”

¹⁷ “6-3-21 Appointment Note.”

¹⁸ “7-26-21 Appointment Note.”

want to accomplish this goal.¹⁹ However, Jade's story was different. She was suffering from a severe mental health crisis and considering suicide, and yet despite being surrounded by doctors, there was no note of any mental health concerns in her records. Even PT Katie, who got to see Jade for the longest, and got drowned out by the master narrative of "returning to her sport" that applied to the majority. Rita Charon writes "the effective practice of medicine requires narrative competence, that is, the ability to acknowledge, absorb, interpret, and act on the stories and plights of others," and in this quote, there is clarity. They thought they were helping her with a classic ACL story, and I thought so too, but as I interviewed her, I realized this story really isn't about her ACL at all: it is about the story they missed, and never addressed. If someone had taken a moment to ask if she actually wanted to return to sports and then dive into why, they may have been able to learn about how she played volleyball before this, to learn about her worsening mental health state and how it connected to why she was playing soccer in the first place, and intervene. But nobody ever asked.

Baby Steps

Her surgery was scheduled for a little over a month post receiving her official diagnosis. She was nervous and excited, as anyone would be for a major procedure, but largely, she approached this operation stoically. This surgery was necessary. In the interim, she would start physical therapy with the aforementioned Katie, who included many inaccurate goals in her report, but correctly noted that one Jade's major goal was to walk again.²⁰ Indeed, she was able

¹⁹ Du et al., "Current Study on the Influence of Psychological Factors on Returning to Sports after ACLR."

²⁰ Jade did not remember many details about her providers, until I brought up her PT Katie. She exclaimed "Oh! I love Katie," and lit up describing random details about how that curly blonde "loved Hozier" and interjected happily that she was "so cute" and "amazing at her job." She would describe Katie as "so human," in contrast to her other health providers, who were like "NPC's" (non-playable characters). Notably, her other doctors switched every session, also because of insurance purposes. I can't help but wonder that if even Katie did not realize her mental health was suffering, how could any of

to regain some of her range of motion and ability to walk about a month after she started PT. It was with a knee brace and an odd gait, but still, small victories! Then, she would go under the knife, and wake up unable to walk at all. How ironic, she thought. There was a brief recovery phase, then it was back to PT, where she would have to start from square one.

She completed an intensive regimen of the physical therapy regimen everyday, which included exercises like “Long Sitting Quad Set” and “Sidelying Hip Adduction” which she was to complete variable sets of 1 time a day, 7 days a week.

For years prior, she had been chasing that next victory on the volleyball court, and then on the soccer field, driven by the fear of failure she felt lapping at her heels if she ever slowed down. It drove her to workout 3 times a day, 7 days a week, plus practice. But then, she was forced to slow down, and the expectations all fell away. As she saw it, “You can't really fail at going to physical therapy [you] just do it... it's rock bottom. Yeah, you like- you gotta *walk* again.”

There were also intensive sessions in person, which included electroshock therapy. PT Katie, with her blonde curls and peppy attitude, would roll over this contraption before spreading cold gel on her quads and attaching 4 electrodes. Every 15 seconds, Jade's muscles would involuntarily tense in an effort to stimulate them to move. It wasn't pleasant, but it was similar to the surgery: without it, “you don't you don't walk! You don't run. There's simply no choice.”

Soon enough, she was gaining back her ability to walk, but her physical state wasn't the only thing changing: When describing her “9 months depression” prior to her ACL tear, she admitted “Everything had so much weight to it.” But after the surgery, there was “very little expected of [her], and that was kind of nice.” Her mental state was improving, she felt “freed.”

the doctors who barely saw her be expected to notice? This points to a structural vulnerability for patients without great insurance coverage.

“I do love a good restart... everything in the past... doesn't count. It counts now.”

Soon enough, it would be time for school to start back up. She walked into her Junior year very differently than she had walked out of her sophomore year, before she quit volleyball and started summer soccer conditioning: I do not mean this metaphorically, she now had a gnarly scar up her knee, crutches, and an unusual gait that would remain for the next year. If there was ever a time to worry about what people thought of you, it would be the year you walked in with crutches after being a star player who turned down varsity the year prior. But she wasn't sizing worrying as much about how others saw her anymore. When you walk in with crutches, you “realize people don't really give a shit, they'll look and they'll be like, oh, she's on crutches. And then they'll just move on with their day. And I didn't realize that beforehand, but then after I was like, well, I can do whatever the fuck I want.”

So she decided, why not stand out more? The year before, she had only worn Hollister brand clothes and had “no sense of style.” She started coming to class very well dressed: and by well dressed she meant like a masc lesbian. Her new style was a noticeable shift, and her close friend Winnie decided to ask her, in the middle of class:

“are you gay?”

“Yeah.” Everyone in the class heard, and she doubled down.

“yeah, I'm gay. Yeah, yeah, I am.”

She imagined that they looked, and they were no longer thinking like, “oh, she's on crutches,” but instead thought, “oh, she's gay,” and then moved on with their day.

Fighting Demons

Whereas Jade's experience with her ACL was oddly beneficial, it is important not to forget that ACL tears still often do have very detrimental effects on athletes. Consider the following quote:

"Pain is not the enemy. Failure is your enemy. Being too slow, missing an opening, miscalculating a pass, these things you control. Doing it right is your only friend, messing up is your foe, and the distance between them is all you are here to care about" ²¹

Demon Copperhead, the titular character of Barbara Kingsolver's Appalachian novel, thinks this on the football field during his devastating knee injury on the football field, in an effort to fight through the pain and get back to playing. What drives him? "Doing right," not "failing." In his way he is quite similar to Jade. Unfortunately, the choice is not up to him, as he cannot get back up after this injury, and will never play football again.

This forceful removal from his sport wreaks havoc on his psyche. Whereas Jade came out of her ACL tear with more confidence and more authenticity, Demon was crushed. This is because for Demon, football is his entire life. He gets injured, and says: "Without football I'd be nobody again." The use of the word nobody asserts that his role as a football player defines him.²²

Eric Cassel's work "The Nature of Suffering and the Goals of Medicine" gives us a lens to better understand Demon's outcome. Cassel's article uses a working definition of personhood including "the lived past, the family's lived past, culture and society, roles, the instrumental dimension, associations and relationships, the body, the unconscious mind, the political being, the secret life, the perceived future, and the transcendent dimension." Casell purports that both

²¹ Kingsolver, *Demon Copperhead*, 383.

²² Kingsolver, 337.

physical threats to the body and symbolic threats to personhood through injury and illness cause suffering.

Demon's knee injury symbolically threatens his personhood, as a threat to his "role" as a football player. It may also damage the "transcendent dimension," which relates to one's legacy and belonging to something larger than oneself, as football was Demon's path to popularity and glory. He suffers because he cannot return to the status quo of his personhood.

Jade's ACL tear was also a blow to her personhood, but in a very different way. Her self esteem and the lack of a sense of purpose or perceived future as experienced by a suicidal person was entrenched in her personhood. Moreover, she was not the star football player, her role was of the reserved, closeted kid, so her sense of legacy as described in the transcendent dimension was different. Her "secret life" included her sexuality, but she thought she would never be able to express it, as shown by her fear that she would never be loved. Jade's ACL tear was indeed a blow to her personhood, but the recrafted person who emerged was more confident, authentic, and wanted to live again. Unlike Demon, she didn't want to return to the status quo: she never wanted to play volleyball or soccer ever again. Cassel accurately identifies illness and injury as threatening personhood, but fails to see that suffering is not the only outcome: it can be a catalyst for positive growth and change.

Without the ACL that forced her out of that environment, she wondered "would I have gotten better? I- I don't know." But just because she grew from her struggles doesn't mean she should have been allowed to get to this point in the first place.

Reflecting on Celina's story has forced me to reflect on the state of modern medicine. It is so powerful and life-saving in so many ways, partially because of its reliance on the scientific method: a reliance on generalizable knowledge, statistics compiled by researchers, which has

heralded progress into a modern era. Think about what would happen if your doctor tested you for every infectious disease that had a “fever” and “sneezing” as symptoms, when all you had was the flu.²³ This would be too costly and ineffective. But it means that individuals slip through the cracks, and one of those individuals was Jade. However, as individuals we can do better. Rita Charon writes, “the effective practice of medicine requires narrative competence, that is, the ability to acknowledge, absorb, interpret, and act on the stories and plights of others.”²⁴ As individuals, we can perform this role for others and raise awareness of the necessity of listening closely to individual stories: by catching what gets left out so that in the future, we can help build the future of a medical system that is aware of, and knows how to listen for, the fringe cases like Jade’s.

“Your Left Hook Could Kill!”

Jade is no longer a 16 year old nursing a torn ACL. She is an Honors Health Scholar and a Social Work major in her freshman year at college, as a first-generation student who plans to go to medical school soon after. She balances her academics with research for her school’s Suicide Prevention for Homeless Youth Project, and volunteers with the Trevor project, which provides a 24/7 crisis support services to LGBTQ youth. She purposefully decided not to join club volleyball, or club soccer even. The passion and desire was gone after her ACL, and during this period she realized her mental health was getting better, and largely attributed it to leaving the environment of her volleyball and soccer days behind her. Instead, this semester, she joined club boxing, and she texted me excitedly that the upperclassman who was training her told her

²³ Interestingly, HIV infection presents as flu-like symptoms for the first few weeks during the acute infection stage, then patients often feel fine for the next few years. People rarely go to the doctor when they have flu-like symptoms, and if they do, doctors would be unlikely to test them for HIV. So often, patients are not caught early on in the HIV life cycle, which has downstream implications on their treatment. *Immunology Lecture 34*, 28:10.

²⁴ Charon, “Narrative Medicine”

“your left hook could kill!” That same morning she went for a run. Though she heard a crack and had some worrying swelling, she got it checked out and was fortunately able to get back to running and boxing easily within a few days. For the first time in her life, her mental health is being addressed by the medical system— she signed herself up for therapy and checked herself into the ER when she realized things were getting bad again. Like she did back then, she continues to pull herself up and thrive.

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